Character Design: The Lady Knight

Lines

1. Shatter.
2. Don't even think about controlling me.
3. Sin is mine to judge.
4. These swords are all you need to know.
5. The secret of Heartflow swordsmanship? I suppose it's writing your heart with the sword.
6. Why do I wear a veil? Well... because it looks nice. My sister said I looked adorable in it.
7. You think I should be more approachable? I'll consider it.
8. This coronet was my sister's. I... miss her very much.
9. Whatever I refuse to accept, I will change with my own hands.
10. Why do I like wearing black? Because if I get hurt, black hides the bloodstains better.

Backstory

Story One: The Rebellion Begins

After witnessing her sister's tragedy, the Knight breaks away from her family.

The Knight is the second daughter of a noble family. She loved swordsmanship from childhood and was very close to her elder sister. As children, the two of them often played at being brides, wearing veils. The family treated the Knight as a pawn in a bargain and betrothed her to the elderly head of another house. But her sister took her place and went through with the marriage, and after the wedding the Knight never saw her sister again.

The next time the Knight saw her sister was at her sister's funeral, only two years after the wedding. At the funeral no one truly cared how her sister had died, and the family was eager to put the Knight in her sister's place as the new tie binding the two houses. By chance, the Knight found a letter her sister had written to her, hidden in her sister's room, describing all the torments she had suffered as a pawn. Seeing the whole of her sister's tragedy, the Knight fled the family on the night of the funeral, taking with her the coronet her sister had worn at her wedding.

Story Two: The Lady Knight

The Knight meets her sword mentor and overcomes her inner demons.

After escaping her family, the Knight came to another domain and entered its knight selection. During the selection she faced discrimination from the other candidates because she was a woman, but she proved herself with her swordsmanship, and her performance caught the attention of a sword mentor. After becoming a knight, she formed a deep friendship with her mentor, and her outstanding ability earned her the first official sword, sash and medal granted by the lord of the domain. Under her mentor's guidance, she broke through her old belief that swordsmanship simply means wielding one sword well, defeated the inner demons, conjured from her family's power, that had long tormented her, and mastered Heartflow swordsmanship. The mentor also gave her three of the mentor's own six swords.

Story Three: The Blood-Red Banquet

The Knight takes revenge on her family.

After mastering Heartflow swordsmanship, the Knight returned to her family. She pretended to accept the family's plan: a marriage alliance with the very house that had tormented her sister to death. At the wedding banquet, she wore her sister's wedding dress. Once all the guests had taken their places, she proclaimed the family's many crimes, cut away the long skirt of the wedding dress, and passed judgement on her sister's killers with her own hands. As she meted out judgement, her white wedding dress was dyed red with blood, yet not a single drop ever touched her veil. When the judgement was over, she put on her sister's coronet and crowned herself the new head of the family.

Story Four: Reunion and Farewell

As head of the family, the Knight negotiates a trade deal with the new lord of her mentor's domain.

After becoming head of the family, the Knight purged what remained of the old guard and took control of the family. She overturned many of the family's unjust rules, which won her the devotion of the people of her lands. To settle a trade deal, she travelled to the domain where she had learned swordsmanship to negotiate. The domain's new lord cared only for profit and made one unreasonable demand after another, and the two sides could not reach an agreement. Holding the old lord's dying wishes over the sword mentor, the new lord ordered the mentor to force the Knight to submit. The mentor thought the new lord's demands unreasonable, but had sworn absolute loyalty to the old lord at the old lord's deathbed, and so had no choice but to duel the Knight. Because the

intent behind the sword went against the mentor's heart, the mentor could not unleash the true power of Heartflow swordsmanship. Torn between the two, the mentor chose not to defend against the Knight's killing blow, but to meet it head-on with a counterattack. The Knight's killing blow landed first. The mentor was gratified to see how much she had grown and gave her the remaining three swords as well. Seeing the mentor defeated, the new lord panicked and offered to drop the earlier unreasonable demands, but the Knight refused to deal with the new lord. She buried her mentor at the place where they had once trained together, and returned to her family carrying the mentor's six swords.

Character PV

No.	Shot	Lines	Length
1	The stage curtain opens, and a small puppet of the Knight is lowered from above the stage.		3s
2	The camera pushes in on the Knight's puppet, cutting to a medium shot of it. The background changes to a dance studio, a music room and the Knight's bedroom. In the dance studio the puppet is made to dance; in the music room it is made to practise an instrument; when the background switches to the Knight's bedroom, one lavish outfit after another is changed onto the puppet.	Knight: Ever since I was little, I was taught to mind my every word and gesture. My dancing must keep to the beat, my melody to the rhythm, and my clothes to the occasion.	9s
3	A small bird flies into the Knight's room through the window. Her puppet tries to follow it out of the window, but is yanked back into the room by its strings.	Knight: This isn't what I want, but the choice was never mine.	4s
4	The puppet's gaze follows the strings up to the hand that controls them.		3s
5	Her sister's puppet is lowered from above the stage and places a veil on the Knight; the two puppets embrace.	Knight: But at least... I still have my sister.	3s
6	The embracing puppets become the real Knight and her sister embracing; her sister wears a wedding dress and a coronet.		3s
7	The Knight reaches out to her sister, trying to hold on to her. The gesture shows how she changes over two years: her hand reaching out (two years earlier), a close-up of her face, her hand drawn back to her chest (two years later).		4s

No.	Shot	Lines	Length
8	The camera pulls back to reveal her sister's funeral. The Knight stands before her sister's grave.		4s
9	Mourners scatter flowers onto the coffin, but no grief shows on their faces.	Knight: Cold. False. Controlling. I've had enough of all of it. My sister's fate, and mine... it shouldn't be this way.	5s
10	The coffin disappears under white flowers; only the Knight remains, standing alone at her sister's grave.		4s
11	Rain begins to fall, and the Knight sheds tears.		4s
12	A teardrop rolls down and falls onto her puppet's head; the puppet cuts the strings attached to it with a sword.		5s
13	The puppet runs, sword in hand.		3s
14	Night. The cries of beasts echo through the forest. A beast blocks the puppet's way, and the puppet drives it off with its sword. The puppet sits alone by a campfire and, looking up, sees a bird flying across the sky.		6s
15	Match cut on the bird to the real sky; the camera tilts down. The real Knight duels other knights in the tournament ring, with emphasis on the killing blows with which she defeats them.	Contestants: A w-woman... a woman knight? How could I lose to a woman knight?	6s
16	The sword mentor walks down from the spectator stands to the Knight and holds out a hand to her.	Sword mentor: The sword's intent follows the heart. The moment you hold a prejudice, you have already lost.	5s
17	The Knight's swordsmanship wins the recognition of the lord of her new domain; before the lord, she receives the sword, sash and medal bestowed on her.		5s
18	The Knight looks up: the figure on the throne before her has become the head of her own family.	Family head: Did you think you could escape?	4s

No.	Shot	Lines	Length
19	The family's power keeps appearing in the form of inner demons. Each time the Knight destroys one, another appears at once; the demons gather and surround her. In the fight, the sword the lord gave her is shattered by the demons.	Inner demons: We told you long ago. Obediently following the family's plans is the only path for you.	8s
20	As the demons surround the Knight, the sword mentor appears and cuts down many of them at once with six swords.	Sword mentor: Your fate is not for others to define. Neither is your swordsmanship.	4s
21	Seeing the mentor, the Knight's eyes harden with resolve; she cuts down the remaining demons with her broken sword.		6s
22	The slain demons turn into the real old guard of her family; the scene changes to the banquet.		4s
23	The doors of the banquet hall open. The Knight, in a wedding dress, walks down a long red carpet; on the throne at its end sits the elderly head of the house who tormented her sister to death.	(Sound: guests chatting and clinking glasses)	5s
24	The camera focuses on a glass of red wine on the long table; through the glass, the Knight tears away her wedding dress. The glass is knocked over, and the red wine slowly stains the white tablecloth.	Knight: The real banquet begins now. No one... controls my fate.	5s
25	The red curtain is slashed through by a sword. Now the Knight's puppet, wielding three swords, cuts down the phantoms of the old nobility in the audience seats. The hand on the strings appears from above, working many puppet soldiers to attack her; she defeats them by severing their strings. The hand presses down on her puppet, and the puppet drives its sword into the hand.		15s
26	The Knight's puppet puts on her sister's coronet.		4s
27	Back to reality: the Knight walks step by step towards the throne where the old noble sat. A wine glass rolls off the table, and as it shatters, she cleaves the throne in two.		5s
28	The sword mentor appears behind the throne.		2s

No.	Shot	Lines	Length
29	The sword mentor attacks the Knight. During the duel, memories of the two of them are intercut through matching movements. At first each fights with a single sword; as their blades cross, cut to a scene of them sparring. When the mentor draws two more swords and attacks with three, cut to the scene of the mentor giving the Knight three of the six swords. Facing the Knight's killing blow, the mentor does not defend, but counterattacks instead.	(Sparring scene) Sword mentor: Steady your heart first; only then will your sword be steady. (Scene of the three swords being given) Sword mentor: Heartflow swordsmanship: writing the heart with the sword. You've done well.	18s
30	The Knight's three swords break through the mentor's attack, and the mentor is struck by all three.		4s
31	The mentor's look of release is shown as the animation turns into black-and-white line art.		4s
32	A bird lands on the mentor's gravestone. Before the grave, the Knight takes up the three swords standing in the ground. Startled, the bird takes flight, and the Knight follows it with her eyes up into the sky.		6s